

DRIVING THE CAMPAIGN
PM Narendra Modi and Tamil Nadu BJP chief K. Annamalai hold a roadshow in Chennai, Apr. 9

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THE MODI-LED BJP'S PLAN TO WIN THE SOUTH BEGAN AT THE START OF ITS 2ND TERM. HENCE THE XI SUMMIT IN MAMALLAPURAM, THE *SENGOL* IN THE LOK SABHA

For Modi and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Tamil Nadu is the biggest southern citadel that they have yet to breach along with neighbouring Kerala, which sends 20 MPs to the Lok Sabha. Both states go to the polls in the first two phases of the general election, on April 19 and 26, as does Karnataka for half of its 28 seats. In the 10 years that it has been in power under PM Modi's leadership, the BJP has yet to win big in the five southern states of Tamil Nadu (39 seats), Karnataka (28), Andhra Pradesh (25), Kerala (20), Telangana (17) and the Union territory of Puducherry (1). Of their combined 130 seats, it won only 29 in the 2019 general election, 25 were from Karnataka alone and four from Telangana. The party drew a total blank in the 85 seats in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Andhra and Puducherry. The overall strike rate in the South was a poor 22 per cent in the seats it contested. Ironically, it was its best ever showing—in 2014, it won 21 seats.